

Session 1: Jacob in the Biblical Imagination

Key Takeaways

- The Bible mentions Yaaqov/Yisrael thousands of times, highlighting the importance of his story for the people who bear his name.
- Yaaqov’s story gives, in seed form, a preview of the story that his descendants will experience from Exodus through the end of the Hebrew Bible.
- The prophets and New Testament authors employ Yaaqov’s story as a lens to help understand their own story.

Yaaqov: The Patriarch of Israel

Yaaqov is one of the most important characters in the Genesis scroll. His story take up half the scroll, from his birth ([Gen. 25:20-26](#)) to his death ([Gen. 50](#)).

Abraham's story takes up 13 chapters in Genesis, and he is very important as the ancestor of the family of Israel. But Yaaqov's story takes up 25 chapters, and he is the father of the 12 sons who will become the 12 tribes of Israel. The rest of the Hebrew Bible tells the story of those tribes.

Yaaqov is mentioned more often than Abraham in both Genesis and the Hebrew Bible.

	Mentioned in Genesis	Mentioned in the Rest of the Torah (Exodus-Deuteronomy)	The Prophets	The Writings	TaNak as a Whole	New Testament
Abram	59x	0x	0x	2x		
Abraham	133x	18x	11x	13x		
	Total: 192x	Total: 18x	Total: 11x	Total: 15x	Total: 236x	Total: 73x
Jacob	180x	32x	98x	39x		

Yaaqov in Genesis and Hebrew Bible. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

	Mentioned in Genesis	Mentioned in the Rest of the Torah (Exodus- Deuteronomy)	The Prophets	The Writings	TaNaK as a Whole	New Testament
Israel	43x	544x	1,487x	432x		
	Total: 223x	Total: 576x	Total: 1,585x	Total: 471x	Total: 2,855x	Total: 27x
<i>Yaaqov in Genesis and Hebrew Bible. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>						

Yaaqov's character in Genesis is foundational for the entire story of the Israelites told in Exodus-2 Kings and reflected upon in the Prophets and Writings. Every aspect of Israel's story influences the way their ancestor's story is told.

Yaaqov has two names in English: "Yaaqov" (Heb. *ya'aqov* = יעקב / Grk. Ιακωβ) which in Hebrew means "heel grabber, usurper"; and "Israel" (Heb. *yisra'el* = ישראל / Grk. Ισραηλ) which means "struggled with El."

Yaaqov's Story and Israel's Story

Yaaqov's story is filled with deception and trickery, exile and return, and it describes his struggle with Yahweh. All of this is remembered by later biblical authors as an explanation for Israel's corruption, but also as a source of hope for a future after exile.

Hosea 12:1-5 NASB

¹ Ephraim feeds on wind,
and pursues the east wind continually;
he multiplies lies and violence.
Moreover, he makes a covenant with Assyria,
and oil is carried to Egypt.

² The LORD also has a dispute with Judah,
and will punish Jacob according to his ways;
he will repay him according to his deeds.

**³ In the womb he took his brother by the heel,
and in his strength he contended with God.**

**⁴ Yes, he wrestled with the angel and prevailed;
he wept and sought his favor.
He found him at Bethel
and there he spoke with us,**

⁵ even the LORD, the God of hosts,
the LORD is his name.

Hosea sees Israel's dependence on foreign powers as a replay of Yaaqov's deceit and lack of trust in Yahweh's promise back in Genesis. Yaaqov's trickster nature at birth continues into his lifelong struggle with God, and this is the same story being worked out in Hosea's own day.

Isaiah 29:22-23 NASB

²² Therefore thus says the LORD, who redeemed Abraham, concerning the house of Jacob:

**"Jacob shall not now be ashamed,
nor shall his face now turn pale;**

²³ but when he sees his children,
the work of my hands, in his midst,
they will sanctify my name; indeed,
they will sanctify the Holy One of Jacob
and will stand in awe of the God of Israel.

This passage from Isaiah recalls Yaaqov's exile as a lone figure trekking to Mesopotamia because that story ended with Yaaqov flourishing in exile with many children. Here Isaiah portrays Israel's future as a replay of this previous story so the now-exiled people of Israel can trust that Yahweh will once again bring abundance to his people in the midst of their suffering.

Isaiah 41:8-9 NASB

⁸ But you, Israel, my servant,
**Jacob whom I have chosen,
descendant of Abraham, my friend,**
**⁹ you whom I have taken from the ends of the earth,
and called from its remotest parts**
and said to you,
"You are my servant,
I have chosen you and not rejected you."

Here the story of Yaaqov's exile and return is recalled and turned into a model for the generation of Israel in exile, waiting for their return. The stories of Genesis have been shaped by the prophets with an eye toward the future.

Jeremiah 31:15-17 NASB

¹⁵ Thus says the LORD,
"A voice is heard in Ramah,
lamentation and bitter weeping.
**Rachel is weeping for her children;
she refuses to be comforted for her children,
because they are no more."**

¹⁶ Thus says the LORD,
"Restrain your voice from weeping

and your eyes from tears;
for your work will be rewarded,” declares the LORD,
"and they will return from the land of the enemy.
17 There is hope for your future,”
declares the LORD,
“and your children will return to their own territory.”

Here the story of Rakhel's death (from [Gen. 35](#)) is recalled and turned into an image of Israel's ancestors grieving over the nation's suffering, defeat, and exile at the hands of the Babylonians. But, just as Rakhel died while giving birth to Benjamin, so also the current generation in exile is undergoing a kind of death that will be followed by a return to the land. Remember that Benjamin's role in the story of Yaaqov's sons ([Gen. 43-45](#)) is pivotal to their entry into Egyptian exile and their eventual return into the promised land.

Ezekiel 28:25 NASB

Thus says the Lord God, “When I gather the house of Israel from the peoples among whom they are scattered, and will manifest my holiness in them in the sight of the nations, **then they will live in their land which I gave to my servant Jacob.”**

Just like Yaaqov returned from exile and was promised land, the generation of Babylonian exiles will be granted the same hope and promise.

Malachi 1:1-3 NASB

- ¹ The oracle of the word of the LORD to Israel through Malachi.
- ² “I have loved you,” says the LORD. But you say, “How have you loved us?” “Was not Esau Jacob's brother?” declares the LORD. “Yet I have loved Jacob;
- ³ but I have hated Esau, and I have made his mountains a desolation and appointed his inheritance for the jackals of the wilderness.”

Here the story of God's selection of Yaaqov instead of Esau is turned into a paradigm for their respective descendants, so Edom's choices and fate will mirror the choices and fate of their ancestors.

Yaaqov in the New Testament

Yaaqov is mentioned in the genealogies of Jesus provided in [Matthew 1](#) and [Luke 3](#). This is part of showing Jesus' identity as an Israelite.

Yaaqov is also mentioned in ways that show how Jesus' story replays and fulfills Yaaqov's story.

- Jesus meets the Samaritan women at “Yaaqov's well,” mirroring the story of Yaaqov meeting Rakhel at a well ([John 4](#) and [Gen. 29](#)).
- Jesus was favored by his heavenly Father and rejected by his Israelite brothers, just as Joseph was favored by Yaaqov and rejected by his brothers ([Acts 7:8-15](#)).
- God's selection of the nations to participate in the victory of Israel's message, while many Israelites reject their own Messiah, was pre-figured by God's selection of the unworthy Israelites and not the

Edomites, which was itself prefigured by the story of God's selection of Yaaqov and not Esau (see [Rom. 9:6-13](#), alluding to [Mal. 1:2-4](#), alluding to [Gen. 25-27](#)).

The Takeaway

Yaaqov's story in [Genesis 25:18-37:1](#) was not collected and written out of mere historical interest. Rather, every part of his story was designed to anticipate and prefigure the later history of his descendants, the nation called by his own name: Israel!

However, Yaaqov's story is not only designed to point forward. It was also designed to carry forward the themes and main ideas of the Genesis scroll so far.

- [Genesis 1:1-2:3](#): God blesses humanity and promises blessing for all nations.
- [Genesis 2:4-25](#): God turns a barren desert into a garden and places his image-bearing representatives in the good land, full of abundance and fertility.
- [Genesis 3:1-24](#): God's representatives are deceived and fail by eating from the death-dealing tree, resulting in their exile.
- [Genesis 4-5](#): God selects one brother for the lineage of blessing, creating hostility between the chosen and the non-chosen.
- [Genesis 6-9](#): The hostility increases to a crisis point and is only brought to an end by a de-creation and re-creation event that results in a covenant and a new blessing.

Reflection Question

How do the prophets make use of Yaaqov's story (e.g., [Hosea 12:1-5](#))?